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Author(s): C. J. Bleeker

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COMPARING THE RELIGIO-HISTORICAL AND THE THEOLOGICAL METHOD¹⁾

BY

C. J. BLEEKER

Amsterdam

This theme gives rise to a series of questions. For the first it is dubious whether theoretical considerations on methodology are very fruitful and attractive. Not improperly it has been said that discussing methodology is like an endlessly sharpening of a knife whilst one never gets something to eat. Such a theoretical exposition mostly is a bloodless argument which some people perhaps read with pleasure, but which is not to the taste of historians of religions. They are fascinated by the religious phenomena to such a degree, that they do not allow themselves time to reflect on the method of their study. Secondly the question arises whether one can deal with the method of history of religions and of theology without taking the object of the two disciplines into account. The method of a discipline generally results from its object. It is wellknown that each science approaches its material in its own way. Therefore one cannot compare the method of the two disciplines without taking their principles into considerations. Thirdly it is evident that there exists difference of opinion on the character and the object both of history of religions and of theology. How can the methods of the two disciplines be compared when there is no *communis opinio* on their principles? Fourthly it can be questioned whether it is useful to deal with the question in the abstract. It is clear that everyone who writes about the subject, starts from certain tacit presuppositions. Some decades ago objectivity was proclaimed as the sole principle of science. Nowadays scholars have come to the insight that how impartial

1) This article has originally been written for a volume on "History of Religions and Theology: Essays in Methodology" which for technical reasons could not be published. Assuming that the subscribers to *Numen* are interested in the subject, I decided to publish the treatise in the journal of the IAHR, C.J.B.

they may try to be, everyone looks at the subject of his study from his own angle, even the students of natural science who were formerly supposed to be absolutely unbiased. This holds certainly also true for the student of history of religions. Though he is obliged to present an unprejudiced picture of the religion which he is studying, he must be conscious of the fact that he involuntarily is influenced by the attitude which he takes to the subject of his inquiry. The implications of this situation are twofold: a) the historian of religions should acknowledge that his method is coloured by his personal outlook on the material which he handles. b) he should realize that he is moulded by a certain religio-historical tradition, which means that he is the follower of a certain national school. In regard to the second point it is mostly forgotten that the study of history of religions is strongly influenced by the cultural, spiritual and scholarly atmosphere in which the study takes place. One can make a further step. The character of history of religions is generally determined by the function which the discipline fulfils in the system of academical instruction of the country in question. Too little attention is paid to this background. Yet the scholarly milieu can be decisive for the manner in which the study of history of religions is conceived of. These spiritual surroundings often explain why a certain method is chosen. The present author therefore doubts whether it is of any use to treat the question of the relation of the religio-historical method to the theological method in the abstract. At any rate it will surely clarify his own standpoint when he starts by sketching the Dutch background of his study. After having described the respective problematics in Holland he can take a further step by voicing some views that have a more general and international significance.

In the Netherlands history of religions is pursued by scholars of different faculties and of different confessions. Historians of religions are to be found not only among the theologians, but also amidst the philologists, the historians, the sociologists, the psychologists, the ethnologists etc. They may be Protestants of different denominations, or Roman Catholics, or persons who belong to no church and do not profess any creed. This fact deserves special notice. The majority of these scholars study history of religions as an interesting subject alongside their actual professional study. They hardly come in touch with theology. They are not forced to confront their method with that of theology. They study religio-historical problems in a matter of fact

way, without caring about the presuppositions of their work. There is no reason why they should puzzle their head about the problematics which is tackled in this article. Now and then their scholarly accomplishments are impressive and surprising. From this fact the conclusion can be drawn that history of religions in principle is an empirical science. It does not pronounce any value judgments, but tries to describe the course of events in an unbiased way, as the students of every segment of historical studies are bound to do. A tendentious description of history is no good. The historian of religions would disqualify himself by showing his predilection or by pronouncing his assent or dissent. Deterrent examples are those treatises on the non-Christian religions which qualify these types of belief as the work of the devil or as the results of human sin.

There are in the Netherlands historians of religions who find themselves in another position. That are those persons who are charged to teach history of religions at the university. Remarkable enough these professorships are solely located in the faculties of theology, both Protestant and Roman Catholic. In principle it would be possible to create a professorship for the history of religions in the faculty of arts. For, history of religions is an autonomous science and is not obliged to reckon with theology or church. This step has never been taken.

There is a historical reason why history of religions is only taught in the faculty of theology. In former times the Dutch Reformed Church was the privileged national church. In the faculty of theology the dogmatics of that church was officially taught. In the nineteenth century the separation of Church and State came about. The faculty of theology became independent and accepted the principle of scholarly objectivity. The result was that by the academic statute of 1876 dogmatics were eliminated from the educational programme of the faculty of theology as a body of professors, nominated by the minister of education. This discipline was handed over to professors, appointed by the churches, who had to train the future ministers. They possessed an advisory capacity at the faculty of theology. To approach the situation from another side, one could say that the majority of the Dutch churches require that the future clergyman shall take his candidate's degree at the university. The churches themselves take care of the training for the ministry. Thus a so called "duplex ordo" was created which can be considered both as an advantage and as a drawback. In this context it

is important to mention the results of this regulation. In the first place it is interesting to know that in 1876 some law makers were inclined to take the utmost consequence of the idea that the study of religion should be impartially scientific. They proposed to change the name of the faculty of theology into that of the faculty of science of religion. Fortunately this step was prevented by a certain connectedness with theology and church which still prevailed among those persons who had to take the decision in this matter. Secondly it is essential to note that instead of dogmatics philosophy of religion and later on history of religions were inserted into the system of academical instruction. In this manner history of religions got its seat in the faculty of theology. Being an independent discipline with a method of its own, history of religions was from the beginning involved in discussions with theologians, especially with those professors who teach dogmatics, about questions of the principles of its study. Some orthodox theologians refused to consider history of religions as a theological discipline. Dr. A. Kuyper, the founder of the Calvinistic "Vrije Universiteit" (Free University) treated history of religions very stepmotherly by relegating it to the appendix of his extensive, threepartite "Encyclopaedie der Heilige Godgeleerdheid" (Encyclopaedia of the Holy Theology) (1894). In his opinion history of religions being the history of pseudo-religion, did belong to the non-theological disciplines. Since that time the tide has turned, also at the "Free University". Nevertheless those theologians who are influenced by Karl Barth are still suspicious of history of religions, because they fear that the absolute truth of the Gospel will be endangered by acknowledging the significance and the religious value of the non-Christians religions. Thus an ever recurring discussion between theologians and historians of religions is the result of the fact that they members of the same faculty.

Unfortunately clarification in this respect is hampered by the fact that there is no *communis opinio* about the meaning of the notion: theology. Different denominations cherish diverging opinions. Each theologian may have his pet conception. Nevertheless two interpretations can easily be distinguished: a broader one and a narrower one. In the first place theology can be conceived of as the organic complex of disciplines in which the future minister should be trained so that he can successfully exercise his office. To these disciplines also history of

religions belongs and that for obvious reasons. The theologian should both have knowledge of the "Umwelt" of the Bible so that he better understands the unique significance of the Gospel, and he should be somewhat familiar with the non-Christian worldreligions, because in a world that is rapidly becoming smaller, Christians and non-Christians daily meet and have intercourse with each other. Thus history of religions has its legitimate place in the encyclopaedia of theology. One can take a further step. There is reason to argue that the method of history of religions actually is applied to other theological disciplines. Which is this method? It is the principle of scholarly impartiality, of purely historical research. In the study of the Old Testament, of the New Testament, of church history, of the history of dogma—merely to mention these historical disciplines—the students apply the same critical unbiased method as the historians of religions. It is exactly this scholarly procedure which guarantees the standard of theology as an academical discipline and marks its difference from theology, taught at ecclesiastical seminaries.

There is a second more strict conception of theology. This discipline can be understood in the original meaning of the word as the doctrine on God and on the salvation which He offers, as the scholarly exposition of the Gospel. The Gospel must be deduced from the Bible and is formulated by dogmatics. This last discipline cannot be studied in a disengaged way. It forces the student to take a decision in regard to the Christian truth. Thus it cannot be avoided that the question arises whether the religions, studied by history of religions, are founded on knowledge of God. If the decision might turn out in the negative, the position of history of religions in the faculty of theology is endangered. For, theology conceived in the second sense, feels itself related to the church and takes it as its duty to defend the true Christian doctrine. Actually there is a continuous tension between these two conceptions of theology, i.e. the academical-scholarly and the ecclesiastical-professing. Both have their right to exist. They balance one another. Thus, this is the place where the problem of the relation of the method of history of religions to that of theology is born. Here it is no artificial question, but an issue of current and existential interest.

However, in itself history of religions is a harmless and inoffensive business, as has already been pointed out. It studies religious facts in an empirical way, like all historians do, without bothering itself about

its method. The situation becomes complicated by the fact that phenomenology of religion has a voice in the matter. In order to clarify this point it should be realized that the notion: phenomenology of religion can be used in an double sense. It means both a scholarly method and an independent science, creating monographs and more or less extensive handbooks. It is this very method which gives rise to interesting discussions. This can only be fully understood when one is familiar with the origin and the principles of the science. In sketching this state of affairs I permit myself to make partly use of ideas about the issue which I have formerly formulated.²⁾

The Dutch historian of religions P. D. Chantepie de la Saussaye was the first who published a treatise on the phenomenology of religion. It is to be found in his "Lehrbuch der Religionsgeschichte" (Handbook of the History of Religions) of 1887. The term: phenomenology is older than this handbook. It is used by Kant, Fries and Hegel in the sense of a philosophical theory about the process of knowledge. Though it is not certain whether Chantepie de la Saussaye borrowed the term from these philosophers it is quite clear what he meant by creating the new science. He must have felt that the study of religions with logical necessity leads to phenomenological investigations. The historian of religions not only studies separate facts, but he also compares elements of different religions and thereby detects parallels and analogies. This is the field of study on which the "Allgemeine Religionsgeschichte" (General History of Religions) and comparative religion focussed their attention. They have become popular, especially among the scholars who adhered the "religionsgeschichtliche Schule" (religio-historical School). Phenomenology of religion took a further step. It started from the conviction that it is more important to try to understand the unique quality of religious phenomena than giving too much attention to outward traits of resemblance. It was struck by the fact that e.g. magic, sacrifice, and prayer occur in a number of religions, yea all over the world. Therefore the question arose which the religious significance of such constitutive elements of religion could be. In this process of research the facts are severed from their historical context and combined in an ideological connection. The result is that one gets a deeper insight into the meaning and the structure of the religious phenomena.

2) "The Phenomenological Method" (C. J. Bleeker, *The Sacred Bridge*, 1963).

Since 1887 phenomenology of religion has rapidly developed. Gradually it evolved into an independent branch of the science of religion. This latter term requires further explanation. For, the issue at stake in this article is so complicated, because history of religion can not be treated as an isolated entity. It forms part of a system of disciplines all of which are in their own way occupied with the study of religion. They are the following disciplines: history of religions, sociology of religion, psychology of religion, phenomenology of religion and in a wider sense also philosophy of religion. There is a constant interaction between these sciences. They borrow facts and viewpoints from one another. They influence each others methods.³⁾ Nobody can study history of religions successfully without securing the help of sociology of religion and of psychology of religion. Particularly phenomenology of religion possesses paramount importance, on account of the fact that this discipline not only offers the heuristic principles and the scientific perspective by which the specialist suddenly gets insight into the sense of the meticulous work with which he is occupied, but it also provides the method, indispensable for the fruitful study of the history of religions. It is this method about which the controversy with the theologians is apt to arise.

In order to understand this working principle one should keep in mind that several students of phenomenology of religion have been influenced by the philosophical phenomenology of which E. Husserl is the chief exponent, or that they at least have borrowed their ideological apparatus from that branch of philosophy. The Husserlian phenomenology is a theory of knowledge, i.e. an investigation, intending to search for pure consciousness. We can skip any further exposition of the contents of this type of philosophy as being unessential for the course of our argument. I should only like to stress that in my opinion it is important to avoid the philosophical implications of the specific Husserlian method. My famous compatriot Dr G. van der Leeuw obviously has gone too far in this respect, as appears from the "Epilegomena" of his wellknown "Phenomenology of Religion". In this chapter he exposes a conception of the meaning of the notion: phenomenology, which may be philosophically right, but which in the

3) C. J. Bleeker, "The Relation of the History of Religions to kindred religious Sciences" (*Numen*, Vol. I Fasc. 2).

eyes of many historians of religions has no direct bearing on their study, yea even might create confusion. Moreover there are scholars, surely not the least able ones, who never theorize about their method, though they actually adopt a scholarly attitude which can be called phenomenological. This means that the reflection on this attitude will lead to the conclusion that it involves certain principles. These principles are generally denoted by two terms of the Husserlian philosophy. They are the epochè and the eidetic vision. The first principle means suspension of judgment. In using the epochè one puts oneself into the position of the listener who does not judge according preconceived notions. Applied to phenomenology of religion this means that the discipline does not concern itself with the question of the truth of religion. Phenomenology of religion must begin by accepting as proper objects of study all phenomena that are professed to be religious. Subsequently the attempt may come to distinguish between genuine religion and false religion. The second principle, that of eidetic vision, can easily be understood. It has as its aim the search for the eidos, i.e. the essence and the structure of the religious phenomena. It is evident that this phenomenological method is the only valid principle for the study of history of religions. On the other hand it is at this point that lively and interesting discussions have their origin.

Phenomenology of religion is a young science. It finds its path fumbling and it stumbles now and then. Nobody can deny that there is an element of truth in the critical remarks which are sometimes leveled at the science. For many years I have acknowledged this by writing: "Actually there is a lack of clarity in the working procedure of phenomenology of religion . . ." In my opinion phenomenology of religion should work out a more precise method and it should sharply delimit the field of its activity. It should keep at a clear distance from the philosophical phenomenology so that its character stands out indisputably".⁴⁾

The attacks which are mentioned, come from the quarters of both philosophers and theologians and are directed against its right to exist, its aim and its method. It is worthwhile to pay attention to this criticism because a review thereof can cast new light on the problem at

4) C. J. Bleeker, *Grondlijnen eener Phaenomenologie van den Godsdienst*, 1943, p. 21.

stake. In the first place the right to exist of phenomenology of religion is questioned. After my "Inleiding tot een phaenomenologie van de godsdienst" (Introduction to a phenomenology of religion) had appeared in 1934 a Dutch reviewer, Dr G. H. van Senden, wrote: "Finally we feel forced to pronounce as our opinion that also this book did not manage to convince us that phenomenology of religion bears the character of a separate part of the science of religion, having its own nature, and to be distinguished from history of religions, psychology of religion and philosophy of religion. It is possible to collect all kinds of most interesting facts under the heading: phenomenology of religion, as this book shows, but thereby its character as an indispensable and essential part of the science of religion is not sufficiently proved". He adds: "A in my opinion hybridic science as the phenomenology of religion brings about more evil than good by continuously pronouncing judgments, not justified as to their philosophical meaning and causing anything but clarification by their edifying nature and their emotional association".⁵⁾ As a consequence of his opinion the reviewer proposed that this science be divided in such a way that one part of its pretended task be allotted to history of religion and the other part to philosophy of religion. The reviewer obviously is the victim of a misconception. The origin of phenomenology of religion clearly proves that it logically developed from the history of religions and that it therefore is an autonomous discipline having its solid right to exist.

Furthermore attention should be paid to the critical remarks which Dr van Senden makes on the phenomenological method. He accuses the science for pronouncing judgments which are not philosophically justified and which by their edifying and emotional quality hamper the clarification of religion. He thereby testifies to his lack of insight into the nature of phenomenology of religion. It never pretended to pronounce any judgment. It even strictly refrains from this act. Neither does it intend to edify people.

In this connection the judgment of Dr Th. L. Haitjema, now emeritus professor of dogmatics in the University of Groningen, on the work of his colleague Dr G. van der Leeuw merits the attention. It runs like this: "The phenomenology of religion shows on three points a lack of clarity: namely 1) lack of clarity in regard to the notion

5) *Barchembladen* 1943, p. 20/1.

“reality”, 2) lack of clarity as to the concept of truth, 3) lack of clarity in its relation to theology”.⁶⁾ This is the typical judgement of a theologian who makes demands on phenomenology of religion with which it by its very nature cannot comply. We refrain at the moment from a detailed refutation of the points of criticism. So much can be said that phenomenology of religion on principle abstains from a judgement on the reality and the truth of the religious phenomena and that an alleged lack of clarity in its relation to theology is not only its fault but equally of theology.

We are brief on the remarks of Dr Haitjema, because they recur in the pointed objections which Dr J. A. Oosterbaan, professor of philosophy and ethics in the university of Amsterdam, has raised, mainly in regard to the phenomenological method.⁷⁾ It can be summed up like this: 1) phenomenology of religion uses the principle of the epochè and of the eidetic vision in an illicit and unjust way, 2) it takes a certain position in regard to the question of the truth of religion, 3) it wrongly pretends to be a science of the essence of religion. This means that Dr Oosterbaan accuses phenomenology of religion of having transgressed the borders of its domain and of having infringed on the field of philosophy of religion. He should like to push back phenomenology of religion into what he considers to be its proper and original sphere of action i.e. the systematic description of the religious phenomena as part of historical studies without claiming to make statements about the essence of religion.

The critical remarks of Dr van Senden, Dr Haitjema and Dr Oosterbaan are exemplary and even up to date, because they embody the misunderstandings which are still prevailing about the relation between the method of phenomenology or history of religions and that of theology c.q. of philosophy of religion. Answering these objections I should like to emphasize the following points:

1) since 1897, when Chantepie de la Saussaye published his first treatise on the matter, the development of both history of religions and phenomenology of religions has been such that nowadays nobody can nor will confine himself to a mere description of religious facts, like the stock-taking in an antiquated museum. The general trend is for an

6) *Vox Theologica*, Dec. 1941.

7) *Nederlands Theologisch Tijdschrift*, Dec. 1958.

inquiry into the meaning and the structure of the religious phenomena. Nobody can put the clock of the historical development of a science back.

2) when phenomenology of religion makes use of the principles of the epochè and the eidetic vision it should clearly be understood that they are handled in a figurative sense. They are void of philosophical or theological implications. They simply express the attitude of impartiality, of attentive listening which is the absolute condition for a right understanding of the import of the religious phenomena. There can be no objection against this procedure, provided that it is clearly stated in which manner this scientific technique is made use of.

3) phenomenology of religion never pretended to be a science of religion. Its only pretension is that it may manage to detect the structure of a greater or smaller complex of religious phenomena. This is quite another business. To put it into other words: there is a striking difference between the way in which philosophy of religion and phenomenology of religion deal with this issue. The first science tries to formulate the essence of religion in a succinct definition. The second discipline aims at understanding the structure and the sense of constitutive factors of religion.

Nevertheless the question of the essence of religion plays a certain part in history of religions and phenomenology of religion. The student of both disciplines start their investigations, aided by a mostly subconscious notion of what religion is. Otherwise they would be unable to sift the chaff from the grain, i.e. the religious from the non-religious facts. Under their researches they may become conscious of this circumstance. This discovery can be a stimulus to articulate the implicate notion. At any rate the formula, born in this way, differs from the mostly lapidary definitions of the essence of religion which philosophy of religion produces. For, it either is a key word, indicating the very heart of religion, ⁸⁾ or it is a description of the structure of religion, according to its elements and its composition, ⁹⁾

4) it is a misunderstanding to assert that phenomenology of religion passes in any sense a judgment on the question of the truth of religion. For, it maintains the attitude of the epochè. It is equally wrong to

8) C. J. Bleeker, "The Key Word of Religion" (*The Sacred Bridge*).

9) C. J. Bleeker, "La structure de la religion" (*The Sacred Bridge*).

blame this science for not pronouncing a sentence on the reality and the truth of the religious phenomena. It balances so to say on the edge of a knife. On the one hand it is loyal to the principle of *epochè*. On the other side it must by force of its impartiality demand that religion should be understood as what it stands for, namely as a serious testimony of religious people that they possess knowledge of God. Even an atheistic student of history of religions must accept this view-point. Otherwise he will do violence to the facts.

5) in regard to the present argument it should above all be realized that the phenomenological principle is a method which can be and actually is applied to different branches of science. It would be easy to quote instances which show that in Holland—as surely elsewhere—this method has found application both in f.i. psychiatry and in natural science. The method possesses an universally scientific significance.

The Netherlands are one of the first countries where history of religions was studied and taught at the university. The development of the Dutch type of the discipline and its problematics may be said to possess an archetypical value. It shows that there has always been a tension between the religio-historical method and the theological method which brought about many profound discussions.

This tension is increased and at the same time put on an international level by the considerations which Dr H. Kraemer at several occasions dedicated to the study of history of religions in its relation to theology. Dr Kraemer who became famous as missionary and as advocate of the oecumenical movement, occupied during a series of years the chair of history of religions in Leiden. In this capacity he received sufficient incitement to reflect on the matter. Kraemer keeps history of religions on high esteem. He does not hesitate to allot to this science its legitimate place in the faculty of theology. Nevertheless he harbours one grievance against its students, i.e. that they pretend to study the religious phenomena fully unbiased and that they deem themselves exclusively able to offer scholarly reliable knowledge of religion, whereas the theologians are suspected of giving a subjective judgment, because they take a certain belief as starting-point of their studies. Kraemer rightly argues that to “understand” or to “comprehend” religion or a religion means to interpret it. Interpretation is not solely or even mainly, an intellectual but an existential activity. In regard to art this is readily acknowledged. In regard to religion this

is easily forgotten, but nevertheless religion is rather the field in which man in all his activities, including his supposedly "purely" intellectual activity, can not escape his existential situation. This idea of "purely" intellectual is one of the fictions of our time.¹⁰⁾ In the opinion of Kraemer those historians of religion who fancy that they work purely intellectual and without any bias, do not realize that they actually build on neo-positivistic presuppositions. This attitude only gives entrance to unengaging knowledge and does not lead to a decision as, according to Kraemer, might be expected from a historian of religions, who is a member of the faculty of theology or who is in touch with theology. He concludes that "the theologian who occupies himself with the study and interpretation of Religion and Religions can and should do so with a good *philosophical* conscience, provided he is ready to follow the well-founded rules of the game." The theologian who studies history of religions in his own manner does, according to Kraemer, not lag behind the official student of the discipline. Yea, he takes a further step. He thinks that "the rightly required impartial love of truth gets the best chance when one tries to look at the phenomena in the light of Christ, the most profound "kritikos" of all things".¹¹⁾ He therefore makes a plea for the creation of a "theologia religionis". This discipline could have different starting-points.

No wonder that also other scholars have proved to be supporters of this new science. Dr Oosterbaan who has already been quoted, is in favour of a theological phenomenology which he considers to be an outcome of a pneumatic theology, of a theology of the Holy Ghost. The latter discipline is explained like this: "one of its elements would be a theological phenomenology of the religious phenomena and of religion, whilst another factor would be a phenomenology of the sciences and of the philosophy in their different modes of appearance. Finally it must describe the transition of religion and philosophy in their culmination-point, where they come together (i.e. in the religious-ontological mysticism) in so far as this can be described as an immanent event."¹²⁾ The programme of the new science sounds somewhat vague and gives no clear idea of the nature of the projected theological

10) H. Kraemer, *Religion and Christian Faith*, 1956, p. 51.

11) H. Kraemer, *De plaats van godsdienstwetenschap en godsdienstfenomenologie in de Theologische faculteit*.

12) J. A. Oosterbaan. „De fenomenologie der godsdienstfenomenologie" (*Nederlands Theologisch Tijdschrift*, 1958/9, p. 97 sq.

phenomenology. One gets the impression that it will stop at *pia vota*. At any rate the programme which Dr Oosterbaan has drawn up by far exceeds the domain of history of religions and of phenomenology of religion in their traditional forms. It is dubious whether there would be many points of contact between the new science and the older ones. In the opinion of the present author this contact is a *conditio sine qua non* of the significance and of the right to exist of the new science. Without the possibility of a close cooperation a "theologia religionis" or a theological phenomenology is a still-born child.

In this connection it is interesting to know that Dr P. Tillich has devoted some words to what he calls a "theological history of religion".¹³⁾ He remarks that "the material presented by the history of religion and culture" is an important source of systematic theology. He formulates this idea as follows: "This continuous and never ending use of culture and religious contents as a source of systematic theology raises the question: How are these contents made available for us in a way parallel to the method by which the biblical theology makes biblical material available?... There is no established answer to this question, since neither a theological history of religion nor a theological history of culture has been theoretically conceived and practically established. A theological history of religion should interpret theologically the material produced by the investigation and analysis of the preresligious and religious life of mankind. It should elaborate the motives and types of religious expression, showing how they follow from the nature of the religious concern and therefore necessarily appear in all religions, including Christianity in so far as it is a religion. A theological history of religion also should point out demonic distortions and new tendencies in the religions of the world, pointing to the Christian solution and preparing the way for the acceptance of the Christian message to the adherents of non-Christian religions. One could say that a theological history of religion should be carried through in the light of the missionary principle that the New Being in Jesus as the Christ is the answer to the question asked implicitly and explicitly by the religions of mankind." It was necessary to make this lengthy quotation in order to do justice to Tillich's intention. The reaction of the present author is that Tillich failed to prove that the

13) P. Tillich, *Systematic Theology*, Vol. I, p. 44.

theological history of religion can be an independent discipline. Part of its task, i.e. in so far as the inquiry into types and motives of religious beliefs is concerned, can be accomplished by phenomenology of religion, whereas the evaluation of non-Christian religions is the concern of theology, c.q. dogmatics. This item should be treated either in the prolegomena, or in the chapter on general revelation, or in the paragraph on mission of the theological or dogmatic handbook in question. Moreover a theological history of religion is strictly taken a contradiction in terminis. History of religions is a historical study. Any attempt to give a theological appraisal of historic facts means a transgression from historic study to theology. Naturally theologians have the liberty to evaluate the historic course of events. However, this is a matter of their own concern and responsibility and is not any longer the business of historians or historians of religions.

Obviously Kraemer has a discipline in mind which works side by side with the traditional phenomenology of religion. He formulates its nature and task like this: "My own line is that "theologia religionis" is an attempt to clarify religion as a human phenomenon, in the light of Jesus Christ, the true man, the normal man, the *only* normal man in his relation to God, man and world." This means that theology and also the faculty of theology must have the courage "to clarify the religion on the basis of solid knowledge in the light of its own standard and to make in this way *its specific contribution to the science of religion*." He adds: "It is utterly astonishing that one has still to fight with the representatives of the science of religion *in* the faculty of theology about this right and this duty as if it was evident and solely scientific to acknowledge without discussion the competence of philosophy of religion to behave as the authority which has the right and is able to produce a normative and regulative idea of religion." What Kraemer says here about philosophy of religion applies in a sense also to history of religions and phenomenology of religion.

The last quotation raises the presumption that Kraemer's proposal encountered resistance. So is actually the case. This goes forth from a discussion between Dr Th. P. van Baaren, professor of the history of religions in Groningen en Dr Kraemer in the "Nederlands Theologisch Tijdschrift" (Dutch Theological Journal) ¹⁴⁾ Van Baaren first of all

14) June and October 1960.

defends the so called “duplex ordo” which in the opinion of Kraemer, apart from its historical value, essentially is an unsound construction. Thereafter he states: “Naturally dogmatic theology has the full right to judge the other religions from its standpoint.” *Theologia religionis*” in the sense of Professor Kraemer is a beautiful and valuable discipline, but it is totally different from the science of religion in the accepted sense of the word and one should not blame the students of the latter science for not practising it, for, it simply is not their concern. However, I acclaim the existence of such a discipline without any reservation provided that it is build on solid knowledge of science of religion in the traditional sense. My only objection is that the results of this discipline should be in any sense normative for the science of the “ordinary” science of religion. The opposite naturally also holds true.” The present author wholeheartedly subscribes this statement. Nobody can object to the creation of a “*theologia religionis*”, provided that it does not claim authority over the ordinary history of religions and provided that it does not pretend to be the true history of religions which offers the deeper insight into the religious phenomena. It is quite conceivable that the new science would supplement and enrich the present religio-historical knowledge and insight. Provisionally the “*theologia religionis*” is a hypothetical entity. So long there is no book of some extent available, proving its right to exist, this new science is no serious partner in the discussion. Moreover it is dubious whether the principal part of its task could not be performed by dogmatics.

In another sense the question of the religio-historical method appears in one of the writings of W. Cantwell Smith,¹⁵⁾ This scholar critically discusses the concept of “*religio*” and the terms which are used for the worldreligions. The scrutiny leads to the conclusion that both the notion : religion and words as Christianity, Buddhism, Islam should be dropped, because they thward the real religio-historical insight. Instead thereof two notions should be introduced, i.e. “an historical-cumulative tradition” and “the personal faith of men and women”. Elsewhere it becomes clear what has moved Smith to make this statement.¹⁶⁾ He opposes to the impersonal character of a great deal on the religio-historical studies. He puts forward the thesis: “The study of a religion

15) W. Cantwell Smith, *The Meaning and End of Religion*.

16) W. Cantwell Smith, “Comparative Religion: Whither-Why?” (*The History of Religions, Essays in Methodology*, 1959).

is the study of persons." This means that his concern is the living faith of men. In his opinion one can only get to know this by conversations with the adherents of the religion in question. This is at the same time the only manner to find a definition of religion which is really valuable. Therefore his conclusion runs: "No statement about religion is valid unless it can be acknowledged by that religion's believers . . . It is the business of comparative religion to construct statements about religion that are intelligible within at least two traditions simultaneously". This approach is by no means ineligible. But it is not always appropriate. It can not be applied to the study of the religions of antiquity, for the simple reason that the adherents thereof can no longer be interviewed. These religions form an important segment of the field of study of history of religions. In regard to the religions of the present it is dubious whether even intelligent professors thereof have a thorough knowledge of their own religion. The expert often knows essential peculiarities which escape the attention of the believers. The conception of the believers must be supplemented and verified by the expert insight of the historian of religions. Therefore the method, advocated by Smith, has only a limited validity. His proposal to eliminate the notion: religion and the terms generally used for the worldreligions can not be accepted. Nobody is blind to the problematics, involved for instance in the term: Islam. But history of religions would be doomed to inactivity, if it were bereft of its present apparatus of notions, how imperfect these terms may be.

Still a third attack is made on the phenomenological method. It is undertaken by people who believe that this discipline should serve social, ethical or religious causes, such as the fraternization of the nations, worldpeace or a better understanding between the followers of the religions of the earth. Congresses for the history of religions generally are attended by some persons who cherish these ideals and expectations. Even lecturers may voice the opinion. A noble and learned spokesman of this standpoint was the late Dr Fr. Heiler. Repeatedly he has with great warmth broken a lance for the idea. His conception can best be gathered from an article, bearing the significant title: "History of Religions as a Preparation for the Co-operation of Religions".¹⁷⁾ He argues therein that history of religions leads to the insight that "there

17) *The History of Religions, Essays in Methodology*, 1959, p. 132 sq.

are seven principal areas of unity which the high religions of the earth manifest" (the reality of the transcendent, this transcendent reality immanent in human hearts, this reality the highest good, this reality of the Divine ultimate love, the way of man to God the way of sacrifice, the way to the neighbor, Love the most superior way to God) and that "a new era will dawn upon mankind when the religions will rise to true tolerance and co-operation in behalf of mankind." It is evident that peace among the nations and tolerance between the adherents of the different religions are ideals which deserve the devotion of all right thinking men. Thus organisations as "The World Congress of Faiths" and „The World Council of Churches" which respectively try to mobilize all believers and all Christians in a fight against intolerance and injustice, and insist on mutual understanding and unity, can make an appeal in wide circles.¹⁸⁾ Whether an historian of religious supports these movements is up to his personal decision. As a scholar he would go too far by contending that this work is part of the task of history of religions. The discipline should keep aloof from such activities.¹⁹⁾ In conformity with the study of history in general, history of religions is charged with the task and presenting a scholarly reliable picture of the religions of the past and of the present. It appears to me that Heiler is mistaken in double respect. Firstly it is questionable whether critical study of history of religions really can prove that there is unity between the higher religions in the seven areas which he mentions. It is to be feared that this is wishful thinking. Secondly the problem of religious tolerance which Heiler thinks will be brought about by mutual understanding of the followers of the high religions, actually is more complicated than he suggests. This has been pointed out by Dr R. J. Z. Werblowsky in a penetrating and matter of fact argument dealing with "Commitment and Indifference".²⁰⁾ He rightly states that tolerance is not only a purely religious affair, but also a socio-psychological phenomenon. He further remarks that the idea of tolerance mostly results from a "philosophical mystical religiosity". Adherents of this religiosity often make the demand on certain religions, i.e. the prophetic ones, that they "should abandon

18) See: Moses Jung, Swami Nikhilananda, Herbert W. Schneider, *Relations among Religions, A Handbook of Politics and Principles*, 1963.

19) C. J. Bleeker, „Wat beoogt de studie van de godsdienst?" (*Nederlands Theologisch Tijdschrift*), Oct. 1961, p. 1 sq.

20) Robert Waley Cohen *Memorial Lecture*, 1967.

some of their basic principles". It is evident that one can hardly expect that this demand is always granted. This means that it is wrong to expect that all religions are able and even are willing to further tolerance unconditionally. Nevertheless there is, as Werblowsky says, "a "holy indifference" that stems from "an ultimate commitment"." The future task must be "to break through, beyond tolerance, exclusiveness and co-existence to the full communion of the pluralist saints".

The preceding argument leads to the following conclusions in regard to the relation of the religio-historical and the theological method:

1) when history of religions and theology claim to be sciences, they are only permitted to use one, common method, i.e. the critical one. This means that they must treat their object according to the criteria of truth and reliability which respective are valid in both disciplines. Unfortunately offences are often committed against this general rule. In both sciences it happens that people work uncritically. They present untenable theses and they manipulate facts of doubtful value, to the detriment of the authority of their science.

2) it has been stated that the specific method of a discipline results from its aim. Therefore a comparison between the religio-historical and the theological method is rather difficult and to a certain extent unprofitable. At any rate in transferring the method of the one science to the other one should act with great caution. However, it has been stated that the religio-historical method, the principle of the science of religion, plays a great part in some fields of the encyclopaedia of theology. This may conversively be the case with the theological method as will presently be shown.

3) the character and also the method of theology in the strict sense of the word are determined by a) its object, i.e. the belief in God and b) its aim, namely the renewal of this belief. On account of its object theology is engaged on divine truth. Being embodied in human pronouncements this truth must be evoked by critical research. In the last resort it can not be treated in an unengaged way. It forces the theologian to assume an attitude, to make a choice, to take a decision. This act includes the task of adapting the divine truth to the present situation and of renewing the Christian faith. When a theologian does not create new theological thoughts, he merely repeats the statements of previous generations and he sticks fast in history of dogmas.

4) history of religions studies cultural phenomena, having a religious

significance, i.e. human actions and words, institutions and products of human activity which testify to the presence of religious faiths. History of religions cannot make pronouncements about God, His existence or His nature. The word: revelation does not fit in with its terminology. At best the historian of religions can make use of the notion: hierophany, following in the steps of M. Eliade,²¹⁾ or say that some phenomena testify to an encounter of man with the Holy. It is not the duty of the historian of religions to create something new. He should respect the facts as they are. He should listen to what religious people tell. He must try to understand the faith of the believers.²²⁾

5) thus there is a marked difference between history of religions and theology in the way in which they deal with religious values. The theologian ultimately assumes a personal attitude towards religious values. The historian of religions acknowledges the existence of religious values and tries to understand their significance. But his method should be completely free from any value judgment.

6) in the context of the argument the general description of the task of history of religions presented in 4) and 5) needs further qualification. The decisive question is in which sense the discipline is taken. Is it an attempt to trace the development of great religious ideas or does it consist in a painstaking research of details, partly of a cultural, social, economic or historic nature, the results of which are published in numerous articles and monographs? In the last case this type of religio-historical work falls outside the scope of the problematics at stake. In the first instance when personal insight and phantasy of the researcher play a part, the comparison of the religio-historical and of the theological method makes good sense and is a burning and highly interesting issue.

7) though history of religions and theology are independent disciplines, they influence one another and they can learn much from each other's method. This interaction could have the following effect: a) history of religions should never forget that religion is always centered round an absolute truth. Moreover it must search for true and pure religion which is mostly hidden among heaps of non-religious or quasi-religious facts. These are two view-points which theology would emphasize. b) theology should realize that in a great deal of its work,

21) M. Eliade, *Traité d'Histoire des Religions*, 1949.

22) W. B. Kristensen, *Inleiding tot de godsdienstgeschiedenis*, 1955, p. 22 sq.

especially in historical studies, the only valid method is that of science of religion. For this method guarantees its scholarly character and its academic standard.

8) more important than the mutual influence is perhaps the fact that the two disciplines charge one another with a certain task and that in the following way: history of religions urges theology to take the problem of the value of the non-Christian religions extremely serious. In an article on "The Significance of the History of Religions for the Systematic Theologian".²³⁾ Tillich rightly says that "revelatory experiences are universally human". He enumerates five points, taken from the study of history of religions, which are in his opinion systematic presuppositions. These remarks show the way. Theologians who are expected to be forerunners in spiritual matters, should have the courage of definitely solve the age-long problem of the relation between Christianity and the non-Christian religions, and that by inserting in one way or another the knowledge of God, present in these religions, into its doctrine on revelation. This is what the modern world expects and hopes for.²⁴⁾ On the other hand the historian of religions can not fully keep aloof from the religious crisis of our age. Many people are spiritually uprooted. The relationship between the followers of different religions is often poisoned by hate, distrust and misunderstanding. Dr Werblowsky rightly remarks: "The students of religion cannot preach mutual understanding, but they are expected to foster strictly by their work a spirit of sympathy and tolerant understanding".²⁵⁾ I myself have once written on this issue: "It is our duty to spread our light to people who do not know properly what religion is. But our task is not conversion to faith whatsoever, but simply enlightening".²⁶⁾

23) *The History of Religions, Essays on the Problem of Understanding*, 1967, p. 242 sq.

24) C. J. Bleeker, *Christ in Modern Athens, the Confrontation of Christianity with Modern Culture and the non-Christian Religions*, 1965.

25) *Hibbert Journal*, Vol. 58, 1959.

26) *Numen*, Vol. VIII, Fasc. 2-3, p. 239.